

FREELANCER CLIENT ONBOARDING TEMPLATE

A done-for-you system: welcome email, discovery call script, contract checklist, and kickoff checklist

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Chapter 1: The Welcome Email

Your welcome email is the first real communication after a client says yes, and it sets the tone for everything that follows. Send it within the first hour of confirming the project — waiting a day signals disorganization before the work has even started.

Subject: Welcome to [Project/Company Name] — here's what happens next

Dear [Client Name],

Thank you for choosing us for your [project/service]. Here's what to expect as we get started:

* Project Objectives: * Deliverables: * Timeline: * Communication Channel (and how fast to expect a reply): * Next Steps:

Before our kickoff call, please review:

* The signed contract and scope of work * Payment terms and schedule * Our communication protocol (below)

Questions before then? Reply directly to this email.

[Your Name]

Use this as a starting structure, not a script to copy word-for-word — the specific deliverables and timeline should always reflect the real, signed scope, never a placeholder left unfilled.

Chapter 2: The Discovery Call Script

A discovery call has one job: surface misunderstandings before they become expensive ones. Structure it around four areas, in this order:

1. Project context — "Tell me about the project and what success looks like for you six months from now." (Not just deliverables — the actual outcome they're hoping for.) 2. Scope confirmation — walk through deliverables, timeline, and milestones out loud, and ask directly: "Does this match what you had in mind, or is anything missing?" 3. Working rhythm — who's the single point of contact, how often will you update them, and through what channel. Vague answers here cause more friction later than vague scope does. 4. Naming concerns early — "Is there anything about working with an outside freelancer/agency that's made you nervous on past projects?" This question alone prevents more onboarding failures than any checklist.

Take notes during the call, and send a short written recap within 24 hours — the recap itself is often what actually gets referenced later, not the call.

Chapter 3: The Contract Checklist

A contract's job is to make disputes boring by settling them in advance. Before sending any contract, confirm it covers:

- * Scope: what's included, and — just as important — what's explicitly NOT included
- * Deliverables and format (a "final logo" is not a spec; "3 PNG files at 2000px, transparent background" is)
- * Timeline with real dates, not "2-3 weeks"
- * Payment schedule: amounts, due dates, late fee terms
- * Revision limits (how many rounds are included before extra rounds are billed)
- * Who owns the work, and when ownership transfers (on final payment, not on delivery — a real distinction)
- * Cancellation terms for both sides

The single most common contract gap in freelance work isn't payment terms — it's revision limits. State a number. "Reasonable revisions" is not a number, and it is the single most common source of scope-creep disputes.

Chapter 4: The Kickoff Checklist

The kickoff meeting is where the contract becomes a real working relationship. Run through this before the call ends, out loud, not just in your own notes:

* Confirm scope, deadline, and next milestone together, on the call * Confirm who the client's point of contact is (and yours) * Confirm the tools you'll both actually use (project board, file sharing, comms channel) — agree on ONE for each, not "whatever's easiest" * Confirm how decisions get made if the two of you disagree on a creative or technical call * Set the date of the next check-in before you hang up — don't leave it as "I'll follow up"

A kickoff that ends without a concrete next-check-in date is the single most common reason projects go quiet for two weeks and then suddenly feel behind schedule.

Chapter 5: Turning One Project Into a Relationship

Onboarding well gets you the first project. What gets you the second one is what happens between milestones, not just at delivery.

Three habits that compound: send a short progress update on a fixed schedule even when nothing dramatic happened (silence reads as "nothing is happening," even when work is); ask directly for feedback mid-project, not just at the end, so there's still time to adjust; and when the project wraps, ask one specific question — "is there a next phase of this you're already thinking about?" — rather than a generic "let me know if you need anything else."

Clients don't come back because a project was flawless. They come back because working with you was easy, predictable, and low-friction from the very first welcome email. That is what this template is actually for.
